Blinded by "Bestie?": An A/B Test of Influencer Partnerships for GUIZIO's Viral Mini Skirt

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Research Question

Does a familiar influencer (one consumers already follow and trust) produce higher conversion rates for GUIZIO's Micro Mini Stretch Skirt compared to a generic, unfamiliar influencer?

Hypothesis

H1: Consumers exposed to the stimuli featuring a familiar celebrity influencer promoting the GUIZIO skirt will display significantly higher conversion rates than consumers exposed to the stimuli featuring an unfamiliar influencer.

Independent Variable

The independent variable for this A/B test will be influencer type. Influencer type refers to the person on screen in the advertisement who will deliver the script. In both variants, the video's caption, product description, lighting, costuming, camera quality, and location will all remain the same. This will be split into two levels:

Control Condition (A): Generic Influencer

Participants will view a TikTok video advertisement for the GUIZIO skirt featuring an unknown persona, preferably a person who does not post online to ensure there is zero bias by participants. This will represent the baseline of a usual scroll on TikTok as the For You page is quite saturated.

Variant Condition (B): Known Celebrity Influencer

Participants will view a TikTok video advertisement for the GUIZIO skirt featuring an Influencer that the consumer already follows and is familiar with. The influencer's profile and

username indicate familiarity, and a grey label at the bottom of the page indicates that the creator is “someone you already follow.”

Moderator

Parasocial attachment will be measured using a series of 5-point Likert Scale survey questions prior to the A/B test. This will feature statements such as “I feel as though this influencer and I would be friends” or “I feel like I know this Influencer on a personal level” and rated on a scale ranging from “Strongly Disagree” to “Strongly Agree.” This moderator is predicted to aid in strengthening the impact of influencer familiarity, as it can be expected that consumers who report greater feelings of parasocial attachment will be more likely to show greater increases in conversion rates. In turn, it can also be expected that consumers that report lower levels of parasocial attachment will be less likely to greatly increase conversion rates due to celebrity endorsement.

Dependent Variable

The primary dependent variable will be conversion rate. This will be measured using the TikTok/TikTok shop analytics which are automatically tracked through the app. The conversion rates that will be measured are video watch time, clicking product link, adding the GUIZIO skirt to cart, and purchase completion.

Additionally, to make an explanation of the response available to the participant, consumers will be asked to rate the advertisement in a series of 5-point Likert scale questions measuring their perception of the ad and purchase intention. Questions might include prompts such as “How likely would you be to purchase this product?” or “Do you think this item’s pricing is fair?” with response values ranging from 1 (not at all) to 5 (definitely).

Research Background

GUIZIO has taken the internet by storm, with its Micro Mini Stretch Skirt emerging as a staple item among Gen Z consumers. TikTok try-on videos featuring the skirt often garner millions of views, yet the physical product itself is made of inexpensive materials (primarily polyester and spandex) raising questions about why consumers are willing to pay $78 for a garment that, by traditional quality standards, appears overpriced. A closer look at GUIZIO's marketing ecosystem reveals a key strategy: the brand's strategic dependence on celebrity influencers. Pop icons such as Sabrina Carpenter, Olivia Rodrigo, and Manon Bannerman (KATSEYE) have all been plastered across GUIZIO's social media pages wearing the iconic miniskirt, seemingly amplifying desire for that item.

While high-profile advertisements and endorsements have certainly boosted GUIZIO's exposure in the global fashion market, a fast rise can bring just as quick of a fall. As more consumers decide to look into the skirt on their own, recent video controversies have been rising for the brand calling out their disproportionately high prices for the materials used. User @sammybanh, who boasts over 1.4 million likes on TikTok, reports "I'm appalled" when realizing that the skirt is see-through (Appendix A). She notes that for the hefty $78 price tag, the skirt should be double lined. Users quickly flooded her comment section in agreement featuring quotes such as "Omg ew why is it so thin" and "Thank god it was refundable."

This dynamic raises an essential marketing question: Is GUIZIO's success driven by product quality, or by the psychological power of parasocial influence?

A study conducted by the Journal of Promotional Management examined how a consumer's reported parasocial attachment to a certain celebrity impacted their impulse purchasing behavior. The study concluded that while yes, higher levels of parasocial attachment

did increase impulsive purchase behavior, the "why" behind this was interesting to researchers. This study was able to conclude that the use of familiar celebrities increased consumer's internal pleasure and arousal, which then put the consumer more at ease when making a purchase and caused them to put less intense consideration into other factors such as financial effects or whether the product truly fit their current needs (Yue et al., 2023). This ultimately ties back to the concept of the affect heuristic. The affect heuristic is a cognitive shortcut in which people rely on their immediate emotional reactions (such as liking, admiration, or positive feelings) when making decisions, rather than systematically evaluating all available information (Slovic et al., 2011). In the context of GUIZIO, this means that existing positive feelings toward a familiar celebrity Influencer can substitute for the evaluation of the product itself, causing consumers to perceive the skirt as higher in value or more desirable because they associate it with someone they admire.

Method

In this A/B test, a group of participants (females ranging in ages from 18-35 to fit Guizio's "young adult" target audience) will be randomly split into two groups, a control group and a variant group. Prior to viewing the stimuli, participants will be asked to fill out a pre-test survey to test their familiarity with the persona in their given advertisement and measure their levels of parasocial attachment to that person. Questions will be answered on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from "Strongly Disagree" to "Strongly Agree" for prompts which probe the person's feelings of attachment to the Influencer. The participants will then be instructed to watch either the control advertisement (featuring an unfamiliar Influencer) or variant advertisement (featuring a familiar Influencer), coordinating to their assigned group. Besides the person delivering the advertisement, all other features of the ad will be the same including the

script, tone of voice, costuming, and lighting to reduce confounding variables. As the participants watch and interact with the video advertisement, conversion rates will be tracked through TikTok/TikTok Shop analytics. After the participant reports that they no longer want to continue interacting with the ad, they will then be asked to fill out a post-test survey questionnaire asking them to rate their perception of the product on a 5-point Likert scale.

Expected Results

The expected results of this study are represented in a bar chart (Appendix B), which features the two levels of independent variables (unfamiliar vs. familiar influencer) and the conversion rates that those conditions ultimately produced. If the hypothesis is supported, it would be expected that the use of familiar celebrity Influencers in the GUIZIO advertisement would result in significantly higher conversion rates.

Discussion

If the expected results are supported, this would imply that GUIZIO's high conversion rates for its Micro Mini Stretch skirt are not driven by the product's fundamental value, but rather powered by the persuasion of high-profile celebrity Influencers. This outcome would support theories of parasocial attachment and the affect heuristic, indicating that consumers rely greatly on prior emotional connection and admiration for figures like Sabrina Carpenter or Olivia Rodrigo when assessing GUIZIO products. Even though the skirt is made of inexpensive materials, a familiar influencer's endorsement may create a "halo" that elevates perceived desirability and increases purchase behavior. From a marketing perspective, these results would provide massive support towards continuing GUIZIO's high-budget investments in celebrity partnerships, as these endorsements appear to increase conversion rates regardless of concerns with physical product quality.

If the expected results are not obtained though, equally interesting insights can still be derived. If it is shown that there is no significant correlation between the generic and familiar influencer conditions, this would suggest that consumers are more sensitive to other factors such as materials used, prices, or other product features such as color or cut than initially anticipated. This would suggest that GUIZIO should take a step into conducting other A/B tests to pinpoint exactly where the concern lies and how to take steps to correct this, such as changing product materials or lowering prices. If the familiar celebrity (variant) condition performs worse than the unknown celebrity (control) condition, this may suggest a growing mistrust for celebrity endorsed products as a whole, leading GUIZIO to revamp its brand strategy to fit the current digital consumer needs. Additionally, we can take a look at our moderator, which measures an individual's parasocial attachment. If conversion rates are only significantly affected by those reporting high parasocial attachment levels, GUIZIO should focus their attention to marketing to those that are most susceptible to celebrity influence and focus advertising to increase the "halo" of their chosen Influencers.

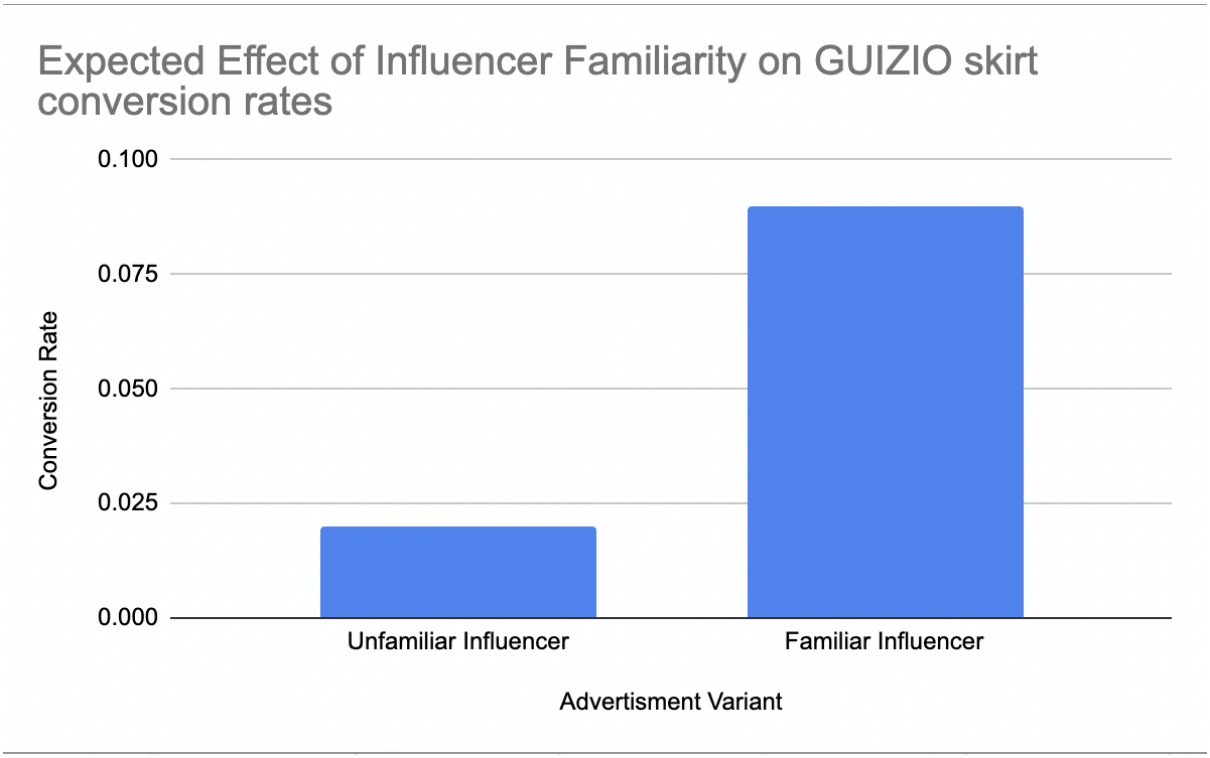
There are several limitations which could come into play during this A/B test. First off is that in an experiment, it may prove difficult to find an Influencer that all participants were familiar with. While participation could be advertised as "Only those who follow Alix Earle!" or "Only those who follow Kendall Jenner!," this may adversely affect the randomization process and lead to a much less diverse sample. Additionally, this test will only be used to test one product, the GUIZIO Micro Mini Stretch Skirt, so the results will likely have extremely low external validity, and may not even prove helpful to the company when it comes to promoting its other products such as blouses and shoes.

Appendix

Appendix A: TikTok by @sammybanh

[@sammybanh], (2025, 2 October). *updated $78 Guizio micro mini skirt review and try on* 👀 [video]. *Tiktok*. https://www.tiktok.com/@sammybanh/video/7556626915419753758?q=guizio%20mini%20skirt&t=1765519668877

Appendix B: Graph of Expected Results



References

Slovic et al. (2011). The affect heuristic. *European Journal of Operational Research.* https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0377221705003577

Yue, X. et al. (2023). The impact of celebrity endorsement on followers' impulse purchasing. *Journal of Promotion Management*, *29*(3), 338–358. https://doi.org/10.1080/10496491.2022.2143994